

FIRESTARTER

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GETTING STARTED WITH "FIRESTARTER"

Hand out the character sheets to your players, print out the attached character summaries, and then have them answer the questions posted below the summaries in the GETTING INTO CHARACTER section. **Make sure to take adequate time with the startup questions and secrets, as they determine the entire flow of the game's central conflict and all of the central protagonists' behavior.**

THE CABAL

BEN JAMES

Ben James grew up poor in Atlanta, where enlisting in the force looked like one of the few ways to a better life that didn't rely on thin odds or a ticket to jail. Ben was

- Sadie Michael - Got laid off from a now-shuttered rural hospital and works here now. Loves singing in church choir.
- Lamar Wilson - Works here part time, works as a gig worker the rest of the time. Lives in a shoebox apartment on main street.
- Jaden Taylor - A rough kid with a good heart--deals pot on the side to help pay his mom's hospital bills.

For most All-Mart employees, you can assume they have upbeat abilities around 45% and downbeat abilities around 35%--these folks have had tough lives. Unnatural should be closer to 60% upbeat - 20% downbeat. (Unless you're doing some kind of crossover and they work at that All-Mart.)

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **All-Mart Staff:** 60%. Subs for: Connect, Subs for: Fitness, Protects: Isolation

deployed to Afghanistan with his squadron, where they met up with a contingent of Whitefire employed mercenaries. As part of their sortie, the troops were meant to find and dispatch a terrorist cell hiding in a small town. When they arrived, Whitefire mercs started immediately firing on the civilians in the village and taking down any soldiers who hesitated. Terrified in that moment, the spirit of the Firebrand moved Ben and he managed to rally the troops to take down the Whitewater mercenaries and work together to cover up what had happened to them. They never uncovered the terrorist cell, however, and the feds became faintly suspicious of what had happened. Ben was redeployed to a base back in South Georgia in Crossways.

It was at the base that Ben met Frank Thomas, who told him about where the stratagem of COIN really came from--Mao, whose writing on guerilla warfare mapped a path to a successful revolt right here at home. Ben and Frank mapped out the swamps of Okefenokee with the help of Dan Cooper and began stockpiling weapons and survival gear. They made a plan to abscond to the swamps while finding a core cadre of sympathetic locals--it was while recruiting Jordan Andrews that they were revealed the ritual to cause the ascension of the Vanguard. Ben would stay behind after Frank's ascension and lead the troops in battle to a successful revolution from the safety of their magically hidden base.

[[[SECRET SIDE]]]

Ben found Frank at a time in his life when he really needed a friend. Chewed up and spit out by combat overseas, isolated from his squadron, and sick to hell of fighting, he didn't think he'd find another man at the base who he could trust. But he did. They became blood brothers, bonded through a ritual into spiritual twins.

Read your secret about Frank Thomas.

Now that Ben has seen this troubling behavior from Frank, Ben thinks maybe Frank's vision of leadership is meaner and less welcoming than his. Ben thinks he can use the blood brothers ritual to trick Jordan's ascension ritual into mistaking him for Frank--if he can manage to swap out their clothes and carry a lock of Frank's hair on ascension day.

DESTINY JONES

Destiny Jones had big dreams growing up--a straight A student with a knack for figures, she was gonna go to business school in Savannah. But she knew her parents didn't have the dough to put her through college themselves, so Destiny decided to take a job where she knew the money was good--as a pole dancer in one of the many strip clubs dotting I-75 catering to truckers and soldiers. But being a stripper actually made good money, and it would have made *even better* money if it weren't for her boss, who cheated her and the girls out of their tips. Something burned inside her and Destiny found she had a knack for something else--the spirit

of the Firebrand moved her and Destiny convinced the other women at the club to strike. It looked like their boss was going to have to bargain.

Instead, Destiny was fired and blacklisted from South Georgia clubs. She was threatened by the local police. Around this time she met a local soldier, Frank Thomas, who admired what she'd accomplished and wanted her help for a more ambitious organizing project. More comfortable with grooming other leaders than being one herself, Destiny helped recruit people to travel to Okefenokee and convinced them Frank was the Red Flag of the Vanguard.

[[SECRET SIDE]]

One night during her stripper days, just when the strike looked like it was going to end, Destiny's boss Rusty and the town Sheriff intercepted her on the way home from the bar--and the Sheriff shot her dead. But while the fire of her life sputtered out, the fire of the Firebrand kept burning. She felt the earth shift beneath her and her body re-materialized back in the bar. A quick glance out the window revealed Rusty and the Sheriff were waiting for her outside. Destiny ran away from the bar and out on her job. She took up with Frank shortly after.

If you have not already, read your secret about Frank Thomas.

After seeing this troubling behavior from Frank, Destiny is beginning to wonder if someone else should replace Frank during the ascension ritual. She thinks she can manage it with another Firebrand if she can juice their revolutionary spirit with some symbolic, cobbled-together gutter magick. Find symbolic trappings that make the Firebrand you feel is worthy seem revolutionary and symbolize their ascension, make sure they wear them during the ritual, and you might be able to make them powerful enough in the eyes of the Vanguard spirit to cause their ascension as the Red Flag instead.

JORDAN ANDREWS

As a child, Jordan grew up on St. Peter's Island in South Georgia, living a subsistence lifestyle with her Geechee family fishing, shrimping, and growing crops. She grew up South Baptist in a tradition that meant celebrating where you came from and having hope in dark times. When her parents were displaced off the islands by luxury development, that hope sustained her when they moved to Crossways. Once Jordan graduated High School, she took on a job at All-Mart and hoped she might work her way up the management ladder. But a few months after coming on, she found out that her co-worker Janice had been fired when their boss found out she was pregnant.

Jordan felt the spirit of the Firebrand move her and created a family of workers at All-Mart out of little more than love, hope and grit. She staged an impromptu walk-out after she convinced her co-workers to confront management about Janice. But it wasn't enough. Her pregnant co-worker didn't get her job back, and Jordan

AARON MARTIN

An elderly black man with a big, bushy beard, Mr. Martin doesn't just know the history of the Crossways area--he knows all of the rumors and gossip, too, including the fact that many's a townsfolk that's seen ghostly presences in the swamp. He knows the location of an old abandoned Victorian that housed a Peace Society cabal and a stop on the underground railroad, and has created maps with likely paths through the swamp that ferried slaves north and supplies to the layout gangs.

If a member of the cabal has a sincere, open conversation about their revolutionary activities and/or makes a successful connect roll, Aaron will reveal that he was once a member of the Black Liberation Army. This was a radical Black Power organization that secretly planned to take up arms for the self-determination of black Americans in the United States. Aaron Martin's politics have de-radicalized in his old age, but he is still an ardent leftist and sympathetic to young idealists, especially since the players' movement is premised on interracial solidarity.

You can assume Aaron has upbeat abilities around 45% and downbeat abilities around 30%.

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Town Historian:** 60%. Subs for: Knowledge, Evaluate a Meter: Isolation, Protects Shocks: Isolation

HARBINGERS

Harbingers are statted like revenants, per pp106 of Book 2: *Run*. All of them have the Urge **Support the Rebellion** at 45%, but it's unlikely that you will need to roll their stats. Reasoning or communicating with them isn't very effective--they can't speak, and their only real goal is to pass their guns onto the Firebrands. Any conservation should be redirected to that end.

ALL-MART WORKERS: JORDAN'S FRIENDS

The All-Mart in Crossways is the self-same one that Jordan and her pregnant co-worker Janice were fired from, so Jordan knows most of the regular staff that work there. There's probably a couple new faces. Feel free to make up workers as needed to help propel the story, but here are a few ideas if you're running short of them and need some NPCs handy-by. (Also, feel free to swap these characters in for any other townsfolk populating Crossways in various stores and restaurants.)

- Rachel Davis: Manager of the All-Mart. Skeptical of Jordan and doesn't like seeing her in the store, even as a customer.
- Crystal Matthews - An older woman with two kids. Tends to mother other employees.

FIREBRAND FOLLOWERS: SOLDIER'S CAMP

These are people that were drawn by various characters to Soldier's Camp but are *not* avatars of the Firebrand. They're useful if the characters need someone to rile up, get on their side, or get in cahoots with. Feel free to ad-lib members of Soldier's Camp that drive the plot forward; these are suggestions if you need names and ideas quickly.

- John Sanchez - An ex-department of corrections officer who became radicalized after seeing the horrible conditions inside prisons in the Crossways area. John is now a prison abolitionist.
- Jayce Myers - A pecan farmer from Georgia, Jayce lost his farm when the price of Pecans became unexpectedly depressed and he was forced to sell to an agribusiness.
- Melissa Scott - a former member of a black bloc organization, Melissa's formation disbanded after a far-right reactionary infiltrated their org and shit-stirred personal beefs. By the time they realized what had happened the damage was done.
- Joshua Phillips - a former legislative aide in the Georgia state house, Joshua became disgusted by the rampant corruption and graft he saw there. He quit his job and decided to join the most radical organization in the state he could find.

The followers have upbeat abilities around 45% and most downbeat abilities around 35%.

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Radical Dissident:** 60%. Subs for: Connect, Coerce a Meter: Self, Provides: Firearms

WHO DO YOU THINK SHOULD TAKE FRANK'S PLACE?

It's possible that, if Frank is deposed before the ritual, the cabal will ask *the followers* who they think should take Frank's place. If the followers are not "primed" to answer in any certain way and are encouraged to be sincere, they will *generally* choose whoever has the highest rank in Firebrand (usually Destiny.) You should leave some wiggle room here based on how players have behaved during the module, though; a particularly selfless or giving comrade or someone with a grand sense of showmanship might impress them more than raw archetype percentile.

If the player tries to convince the followers that their PC should ascend, you should have the player channel their Firebrand ability, possibly with an assist from their other identity if it makes sense. (See "FROM EACH ACCORDING TO THEIR ABILITY (CHECK)".) If they succeed and make a good case through RP, the followers will change their minds on who to back. Of course, if another Firebrand talks to them *afterwards*... they might be able to swing their "vote" again. Politics!

lost hers too. Jordan went to Crossways church to pray for a sign, and she found one--a ritual to immanentize the eschaton and create a secret base for a revolutionary uprising in the swamps of Georgia--a ritual that was weaved together by runaway slaves, abolitionists, and Confederate deserters. Shortly after she met Frank Thomas. When Frank told Jordan about his plans to become the Red Flag of the Vanguard in the collective mind of humanity, Jordan realized that meeting him was a sign--a sign that Frank was the one destined for the ritual she had found.

[[SECRET SIDE]]

Read your secret about Frank Thomas.

After seeing some troubling behavior from Frank, Jordan has begun to suspect that maybe there was a reason *she* found the ritual after all--looks like maybe God's telling her the Red Flag of the Vanguard that ascends is gonna have to be someone else... someone like *her*. She thinks she can tweak the ritual to cause the ascension of a different soul in the ceremony than Frank. Read **THE RITUAL** and collect any necessary components (You might need some help). The ritual works best on whoever channels the spirit of the Firebrand the most, so look for ways to strengthen it.

THE RITUAL

- First, the candidate for ascension must free a trapped/bound innocent from their binds. This need not be literal but should be symbolically potent. Jordan knows just the thing--a mummified dog known as "Chipper" that got stuck in a hollow chestnut tree that's located at the local "Treeseum," a museum in Crossways dedicated to the history of trees.
- Sing "Solidarity Forever" and "John Brown's Body" simultaneously, acapella, in harmony.
- Circle Widdershins in a circle in time to meter. The candidate for ascension must also circle, as they are of and among the people they fight for.
- The candidate for ascension must hold the gun of an American Rebel who fought for the people. Someone similar to them is good. Someone who was part of a rebel conflict is better. *Both* are best.

WHO ARE THE GULLAH GEECHEE?
The Gullah Geechee are a group of Black Americans who live in the American south and speak a variant of Creole known as Gullah. You could write whole books (and people have) about their heritage, but they are a creole black culture, and Jordan in particular comes from the coastal islands of South Georgia where the Geechee historically (and marginally still do) live a "off the land" farming lifestyle and sell excess produce to make a small profit, oftentimes to larger agribusinesses. Most Gullah Geechee are raised Baptist and their stories and culture are rooted in West Africa and the Black American struggle.

If you don't know much about black creole culture that's okay--Jordan left the Island in high school and may only connect with it as distant nostalgia, the way a lot of us connect with our homes after "moving away."

DAN COOPER

Dan grew up in Northern New Jersey in a town full of deteriorating ranch houses and dead American dreams. His afternoons in the library turned into a passion for history, and he pursued a degree in it at nearby Queen's College. Getting a PhD felt like burning the candle at both ends sometimes but he was passionate about his research and passionate about teaching. And passionate about Marx.

Thousands of dollars in debt later, Dan wasn't able to find anything for a job outside of an adjunct position at East Georgia state. He couldn't afford to eat without dumpster diving, he was sleeping in his car, and he'd never felt more alone--until a casual adjunct meetup for East Georgia revealed half the staff were doing the same. Dan felt the spirit of the Firebrand move him and he channeled every ounce of the stirring communist theory he read into an impromptu adjunct strike. East Georgia was forced to come to the table and increase adjunct pay and benefits--but his own job was forfeit as the administration realized who was stirring up trouble.

Not long after, Dan met Frank, who was impressed by what he accomplished in a right-to-work state. Although Dan isn't much of a soldier, his command of military history and communist struggle is second to none, and he has been no small force in helping Frank create a viable plan for guerilla warfare in the South Georgia swamps.

[[SECRET SIDE]]
Read your secret about Frank Thomas.

Dan is beginning to question if Frank has the ironclad virtue required to serve as a spiritual figurehead for their movement. But maybe the same kinds of synchronicity and symbolic potency that power Jordan's ritual and the ascension could work the other way around--like bad juju, Dan could throw a mystical whammy on Frank Thomas that could hamstring his power as a Firebrand; if he can cobble together a ritual that symbolically weakens him. Find items that symbolically represent the target of your whammy and harm the components in some way that has symbolic resonance with the ascension ritual. The mystical whammy could be enough that a normally weaker Firebrand might look like a stronger figurehead in the eyes of the

Another good way to fuck over Frank is that Frank, as an ex-marine and a guy with a... pretty flexible sense of self (and the associated propensity to *Lie*) has a hefty 22 hardened notches. Three nasty stress checks he has to roll for and he's *burned out* if he passes them, which means he can't channel his Avatar path--and that means he can't ascend.

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Rage Stimulus:** Being called out
- **Noble Stimulus:** Inspire the workers to revolt
- **Fear Stimulus:** Followers have no loyalty (Isolation)
- **Ex-Marine:** 50%. Substitutes for: Struggle, Provides: Firearms, Subs for: Status
- **Demagogue (obsession):** 75%. Casts Rituals, Gutter Magick

Frank Thomas				
Shock Meter	Hardened	Failed	Abilities	
Helplessness	3	0	Fitness 50%	Dodge 30%
Isolation	3	0	Status 50%	Pursuit 30%
Self	5	3	Knowledge 40%	Lie 40%
Unnatural	4	0	Notice 45%	Secrecy 35%
Violence	7	2	Connect 30%	Struggle 50%

Here are the Demagogue's channels. Again, more detail can be found in *Book 5: Mine* on page 41.

The Demagogue
1-50%: After 30 mins of engagement, the Demagogue can: • Push someone's beliefs in a direction of their choosing. • Knows their core beliefs and what will drive them • Knows if they're a faker or covering their true beliefs Effects last for minutes equal to the roll.
51-70%: • The Demagogue can suss out what someone wants to believe, as well as what they do believe. • They can push their beliefs in a direction of their choosing. Effect lasts for hours equal to the roll.
71-90%: • By focusing for a day, the Demagogue can plant an idea in the collective unconscious or memetically engineer an idea into society. (But not the mainstream.)

Here is what is canonically true about Frank Thomas at the beginning of "FireStarter":

- We know that Frank found out about Mao after his involvement in COIN (the CounterInsurgency program) as a Marine in Afghanistan. He met Ben Jones and passed on this knowledge to him, and they both began preparation for their base in Okfenokee.
- Frank trusts Destiny enough to sleep in the same tent as her and have her lead recruitment.
- Frank believes Jordan's ritual is real and will help Frank ascend.
- Frank trusts Dan's judgement enough to help lead his military strategy.

But his personality on a face to face basis should be informed primarily and mostly by what the players say about him in the GETTING INTO CHARACTER section, because the game is more interesting if the characters build him up before the secrets break him down. Also, as a Demagogue, he's *very good* at manipulating people's views and leanings, which means he's also good at presenting himself in a way that the player character will find likeable and sympathetic. You should take every opportunity you can when playing Frank Thomas to try and tell the player characters what they want to hear. It's tempting to see Frank as a cartoonish, mustache twirling charismatic leader, but remember, a good organizer listens 80% of the time and talks 20% of the time and *Frank is the best organizer of all of these people*. Have him ask them a lot of questions and use his channels to suss out what they want to do and only then have him use his channels to try and influence their opinion. Feel free to lie like crazy, as long as the lies are believable and won't fuck him over down the line.

As a Demagogue, Frank can influence what the players believe, including what they believe about *him*. And as a Demagogue, he can *never* admit he's wrong or else he will risk breaking his taboo and losing percentile in *Demagogue*. (though making him do this is a good way to help take him out of the running for ascension.) *Book 5* doesn't give very specific consequences for players who are insistent in not believing something the Demagogue says when using a channel, but the general rule of thumb is that resisting mind-control powers of this type is a stress check, and it's impossible to *make* a player believe something if they're willing to eat the check. The more "in line" with the cabal-members beliefs the idea he's trying to implant is the *higher* the stress check should be, and generally it's going to be *isolation* or *self* (occasionally *helplessness*). In terms of rank, telling a player to believe something that's out of line with their ideology should be a much lower stress check than saying something they're already inclined to believe. For example, something like "Well, making sexually charged comments about a comrade I oversee isn't a big deal" should be fairly easy to resist, with a self check in the order of 3-5. Most leftists uncontroversially believe this is bad. Something like "We're fighting a war and we can't afford someone narking on us to the cops, so we really need that blackmail material if you're a good comrade" should be much harder, an isolation check of 7-9, because he's invoking their loyalty to the cause and most headline leftists consider narking one of the shittiest things you can do and definitely an existential threat to, uh, an armed revolution.

cosmos than Frank--Maybe even you could ascend and make sure the most effective strategy is embedded in the revolutionary spirit of the new era.

RELATIONSHIP WITH FRANK	FRANK'S DARK SECRET
FAVORITE (Frank is your closest friend or lover)	Recently Frank revealed to you that when he learned an "ally" was scabbing on an All-Mart picket line a year ago, he followed them home and shot them.
GURU (You look up to Frank for personal or spiritual advice)	Recently you've heard Frank make inappropriate, sexually-charged comments about you or the cabal-mate with whom you have a relationship when no one else was around. If he acted on them, they would be sexual assault. You don't know if he has or plans to. If he said them <i>to you</i> , they're definitely harassment.
MENTOR (You look up to Frank for advice on how to organize and lead the revolution)	Recently a member of your Maoist cell, Melissa Scott, expressed reservations about the ritual and is thinking of going home. When you mentioned it to Frank, he suggested that you should find blackmail material to prevent her from narking.
RESPONSIBILITY (You feel responsible for Frank's decisions and actions)	Frank suspects that the cabal-mate you have a personal relationship with is trying to depose or replace him. He has suggested that you spy on them and kill them if you find a smoking gun.
PROTÉGÉ (You're mentoring Frank as an organizer)	Frank asked you to collect an item for this ritual--the gun of a confederate deserter who helped escaped slaves named ROMULUS MORGAN--and you weren't able to do it. When you let him know, he lost his temper and hit you.

A GLOSSARY OF MAO AND MARX

I don't personally think it's very important for players to understand much about Marx or Mao when playing this game, but then I'm a very "the struggle is political education!" kind of leftist. That said, if you really want to play up the fact that the characters are Maoists it's nice to know a little bit of Maoism 101. So here's some common Marxist and Maoist terms. This glossary explains the terms the way that people who think that they can cause the spiritual ascension of a cosmic

revolutionary would use them, not people who are being, you know, restrained and nuanced in their use of vocabulary.

Communism - *not* when the Government does stuff. Communism is the end goal: a society where all things are in common and class, money, and the state is abolished. "From each according to his ability, to each according to his need."

Dialectical Materialism - the fundamental insight that Marxism is not only the only way to understand human history - it is also the only way of understanding the natural world - evolution, matter, the cosmos, chemical reactions, you name it! Without Marxism, you are like a little baby.

Liberalism - In Mao's **Combat Liberalism**, Mao basically says, "Liberals are people who don't tell someone they've fucked up to their face and instead gossip about it behind their back." Among many Maoists and Marxists, Liberalism can become lazy shorthand for "something I don't like about your personal behavior."

The Little Red Book - A book of famous quotations from Mao about how to lead communist struggle. Much broader in scope than *On Guerrilla Warfare*, it's the cliff notes to Maoist thought. [Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Red_Book) has a pretty decent synopsis you could read in five minutes or so.

Reactionary - A reactionary is someone who longs for a return to an idealized, conservative past. All fascists are reactionaries but not all reactionaries are fascists. But most reactionaries are fascists. Informally, it often refers to ideas that are either too authoritarian (that is, not liberatory) *or* ideas that are too individualist (that is, not collectivist), depending on who you ask.

Revisionism - When you reinterpret Marxist ideology, with the implication you're interpreting it to be more Liberal. See "**Liberalism**."

Struggle Session - A struggle session is essentially a form of humiliation where members of an aggrieved group gather to inform the guilty party of their crimes and force them to publicly admit wrongdoing.

I DON'T KNOW JACK SHIT ABOUT MARX

Folks who choose to play Dan Cooper, the PhD Political Theorist, may feel uncomfortable with their lack of knowledge about Marxism.

Honestly, it's not a big deal. Feel free to have them gloss any theory as long as it sounds pretty Marxist-ish! If they want to know a little ahead of time to "get into character", Wisecrack's five-minute video on Marxism from their *8-Bit Philosophy Series* (S1E9), "What is Marxism", is honestly an excellent introduction and tells you basically what you need to know to play Dan.

APPENDIX

RITUAL: ASCENSION OF THE VANGUARD

- First, the candidate for ascension must free a trapped/bound innocent from their binds. This need not be literal but should be symbolically potent.
- Sing two hymnals that represent your man of the people in the manner of the Sacred Harp, simultaneously.
- Circle widdershins in time to the meter of the hymnal.
- The candidate for ascension must hold the gun of an American Rebel they identify with who fought for the people.
- As the candidate walks to the hymnal, they will be known for ascension by the sidearm they carry and their role in the freeing of the innocent. Their soul will ascend on the wings of justice and its wake will be the pole of a tent of safety and succor for those fighting the good fight for the freedom of men.

HOW THE RITUAL WORKS

The ritual works by padding any avatar's power by 20% who is on an avatar path that "fights for the people" and fulfills the requirements of the candidate in the ritual. If you're using this ritual for a game outside of this one, the following archetypes in *Book 1* could satisfy this description:

- The Firebrand (obviously)
- The Guide
- The Solid Citizen
- The True King
- The Unsung Champion
- The Warrior

Note that just because your avatar is on this list doesn't mean that you automatically qualify for the ritual. If you're a True King but you fight to make your college more exclusive and conservative, it's hard to argue that you fight "for the people." If you're a guide but you're a cartographer and not a union shop steward, the ritual is going to be a dud.

FRANK THOMAS

Frank Thomas is the avatar all the characters begin the story backing to ascend as the Red Flag of the Vanguard. Frank Thomas has a secret, too, though--he's not an avatar of the Firebrand at all. He's actually the avatar of the **Demagogue** (See pp41 of *Book 5: Mine* for details), which is roughly outlined below.

Appearance-wise, Frank is in his mid to late thirties, pretty jacked from his military training and dedication to the cause, and a former Marine. Many of the characters in this game have deliberately ambiguous racial backgrounds (except Jordan, whose background as Gullah Geechee means she is definitely Black American) but Frank is white, and he has brown hair and eyes.

THE MIXED ENDING

In this ending, Dan lays his whammy on Frank, but all of the characters use their own rituals on themselves--Destiny juices herself to 98% without eeking out that last 2% or juices Ben or Dan instead of Jordan, Jordan makes herself the candidate for the Ascension ritual, and Ben James casts the proxy ritual on himself. In this ending, no one ascends. Even if Ben James' proxy ritual triggers, because Frank himself does not have enough avatar mojo to ascend, it doesn't matter. The ghosts of deserters, slaves, and union men rise and create the shadow base, but it's very unclear if *The Vanguard Spirit* has the charisma and revolutionary fervor to convert enough people to their cause without an archetype pulling the strings.

THE BAD ENDING

In this ending, some or all of the players pull for *Frank*, either giving him the positive shift he needs to ascend, declining to whammy or proxy him, or even *worse*, taking his side in the conflict and revealing other players to be plotting against him. The ghosts of deserters, slaves, and union men rise and create the shadow base, but a burning feeling of anger and fervor rises within the players. They feel in their hearts the only way for mankind to be better is brutal, unrelenting war, until the name of Frank Thomas is on the lips of the entire country and then the world.

EPILOGUE: MAKING IT PAY OFF

Part of the tension of ending *Firestarter* is there's no way for the players to know if these rebel Maoists will be successful. Like so many nascent movements, the ending, if pulled off, leaves the promise of hope and the determination to fight but makes no promises for what the future holds. If I were GMing, I think I would prefer to end the game on the climax, as the Vanguard of the Revolution rises and the players wonder what the future will bring.

That said, if Frank is still around and hasn't ascended, your players may end up essentially playing out the COMBAT LIBERALISM section after the game's climax. "What to do with Frank" is too important a question to leave the PCs hanging on, and a final confrontation with Frank is honestly as exciting a climax as the ascension itself--so I don't recommend glossing over it unless the clock is really ticking.

Finally, it's possible that there may be interpersonal conflicts that aren't entirely resolved in the short-term during the one-shot, and those *might* be worth playing out, depending on how tense the inter-player dynamic is. Regarding leadership, though: **whichever player remaining ends the one shot with the highest percentile in Firebrand is the usually presumptive new leader of the Maoist rebellion**, and the followers should react appropriately to their supernatural aura of authority.

GETTING INTO CHARACTER

- Tell your players to select a character from the sheets put in front of them. Print out the character descriptions and affix them *on top* of the character sheet; it's best to pick without looking at the stats first, but if the players feel strongly that they want to see the sheet, don't stop them.
- The four of you have gathered in the swamps of Okefenokee from various parts of Southeastern Georgia because you were convinced by Frank Thomas that completing a ritual your cabalmate, Jordan Andrews, found in a Baptist Church would cause him to ascend into the collective unconscious of mankind and inspire Americans to back a Maoist rebellion. That ritual will also create a secret pocket space for your base on Soldier's Camp in the swamp--a hideout that's *supernaturally hidden* from potential police or federal agents. Now you're trying to collect the last of the ingredients you need for the ritual while you prepare the base in the swamps for a long guerilla campaign.
- Read the character descriptions attached to your sheet, then look briefly through your sheet to familiarize yourself with any powers or identities you have.
- Most Activists have a moment that radicalized them--that shook them enough to try and shake up the world. Each of *these* activists had a moment where they were not only radicalized, but knew they had a *supernatural holiness* they could channel to radicalize *other people*. This is your *Firebrand* identity. Explain the rules for Firebrands and obsession identities to your players if you have not already.
- Every member of the cabal was drawn to Frank Thomas' lofty goals--enough to walk away from their lives and join his cause. Pick one of the five relationship roles and populate Frank Thomas in that role, putting the same percentile that corresponds to the stat beneath the role. Each player must choose a different role for Frank--no repeats. For example, if your character cares more about Frank than anyone else, you might put him as your favorite. Why do you see Frank that way? Explain your relationship with Frank in a couple of sentences.
- Now Pick a relationship role for the Cabal, putting the same percentile that corresponds to the stat beneath the role. This is how you see your cabal-mates as a whole; if you feel like you need to take care of them, for example, they're your responsibility. If you look up to them for organizing advice, they're your mentors. Unlike Frank's role, more than one player can choose the same role for their cabal.
- Pick a relationship role for **one** other player, putting the same percentile that corresponds to the stat beneath the role. This is the kind of relationship you have with that character. For example, if Jordan feels she's a role model to Ben, she might make him her protégé. Talk to the player about how you see their relationship. Unlike Frank's role, more than one player can choose the same role for another player.
- Each character has a secret, something that only they know. I'm going to hand out the secrets now. It's important to note the Firestarter isn't a "hidden role" game--once you read your secret, you're free to act on it, or

not, however you wish. You're free to tell all of the PCs, only certain characters you think you'd trust, or no one at all. You're free to reveal everything you read or none of what you read. But anything you tell or don't tell other people about your secret must be *in character*.

FROM EACH ACCORDING TO THEIR ABILITY (CHECK)...

Some players may find the starting character sheets unfair if they become invested in the competitive, "who gets to ascend" aspect of the game. It's just easier for some characters--like Destiny--to ascend based on pure Firebrand stats than others.

As the GM, if characters are using their other identities to organize, I recommend giving them shifts on subsequent Firebrand rolls. If Dan makes a great speech using his theory knowledge, or if Jordan channels the stirring spiritualism of her Baptist heritage, or if Destiny has a 1:1 with another follower bringing them to her way of thinking, or if Ben shows the discipline or skill of a former Marine--it's realistic to assume they might make a better case as part of their second Firebrand channel and be awarded a 10-20% shift. You should offer this to players with successful rolls of their other identities, when appropriate.

SUMMARY

Four Maoist activists abscond to the Okefenokee swamps of South Georgia with a singular purpose: immanentize the revolutionary eschaton and ascend their leader as the Red Flag of the Communist Vanguard, ushering in the beginning of a glorious American worker's revolution.

BACKGROUND

"Lenin walks around the world.
Black, brown, and white receive him.
Language is no barrier.
The strangest tongues believe him."
-Langston Hughes

After being sent through the ringer--beaten down and thrown out by a society that doesn't give a rat's ass--four young organizers realized they had the ability to inspire, organize, and drive those around them to accomplish... more. More than Martin Luther King Jr., more than Eugene Debs--actual, honest-to-goodness supernatural organizing power that can bend the will of the rank and file. How? By following the path of an Archetype, an abstract ideal embedded in the subconscious zeitgeist of humanity--the Firebrand.

With power like that, a union drive or a general strike wasn't enough, not enough by half--only full-scale guerilla warfare in the forgotten swamps of Okefenokee is enough to launch the revolution four Firebrands need to see in the world. An idea that might seem crazy to an ordinary organizer feels tantalizingly within the grasp

ROLL	RESULTS
1-25	The followers watch in awe as the Red Flag of the Vanguard ascends in a pillar of light, witnessed by fallen American rebels who fought for the people.
26-50	The followers watch in uneasy silence, perhaps clinging to each other in fear or making their way to their campsite with the intention of leaving Soldier's Camp.
51+	The tens digit is how many followers have blown a stress check and are freaking out.* If any of the players are behaving in a way that escalates the situation or draws negative attention to them, they should take damage equal to the two digits added together. (So if a 55 is rolled, they will take 10 damage.) If a player is escalating the riot with violence, a follower will pull a gun on them and do damage equal to the roll itself. (So in that case, a 55 does fifty-five damage. Nasty.)

*In Book 2: Run, it's the two digits added together. But there's only a dozen followers at the camp at most, and it doesn't make sense for 18 people to fail a stress check if that's more people than are present in the camp.)

FINALE: POSSIBLE CONCLUSIONS

There are many possibilities for how **Firestarter** can end depending on which magical cocktail the players mix up of their respective rituals and avatar channels. But there are four main potential endings, and, well, let's not beat around the bush about which one is which. Feel free to mix it up depending on what you think is going to be the most narratively satisfying and the exact combination of factors.

THE BEST ENDING

In this ending, the players all juice their positive shifts to a single candidate--or one candidate gets at least 100%. Dan lays his Whammy on Frank, Frank gets below 80% in Demagogue, or Frank is gotten rid of before the ascension, and the players collect everything needed for the ritual. This ending occurs if the players are maximally cooperative. The Best Ending is actually pretty common, which restores my faith in humanity a little. Or at least my faith in my playtesters.

THE GOOD ENDING

In this ending, Destiny juices herself instead of another Firebrand, getting herself at 100% for the ascension, or another candidate gets to 100% somehow. Dan still lays his whammy on Frank, taking him out of the running. *Note that Destiny needs to eke away 2% from another Firebrand using her first channel for the Good Ending to work.* Why does a good ending result from Destiny being uncharacteristically selfish? Sometimes being a good leader is looking around the room and thinking, "Jesus, I may not be the best candidate, but I'm better than these guys and someone has to be the adult in the room."

and underground railroad conductors rise above them, forming a canopy above their hideout like the canopy of a tent. As the ghosts rise in this canopy they coalesce around a central pillar of light (The same light the ascension takes place in) and dissolve. A chorus of whispers intones, "To enter or leave the tent of miracles, hold the gun of the rebel dead." Then four red, rusted guns appear on the ground, corresponding to each of the possible Harbingers, except for the one representing whomever ascended.

Once the guns appear the ghosts all fade away, including those dancing and singing with the players, and a faint haze in the shape of a tent hovers over the players where the shadow realm has been created. If Frank Thomas has ascended, the tent should take on the palest hint of red.

A RIOT ROLL

There are enough people here that you can justifiably, if you so wish, make a *riot* roll per the rules on pp94 of Book 2: *Run*. Under the circumstances of the Best, Good, or Mixed ending (see: FINALE: POSSIBLE CONCLUSIONS pp31), a riot roll is going to start at an automatic -30 shift, however, since the crowd is receptive, the effect is beautiful (well, to communists), and it is beneficial to someone. If I were GMing, I probably wouldn't roll for a riot if the players attain the Best/Good ending, and maybe not even if they get the Mixed ending, depending how back-stabby and mean they were throughout the course of the one-shot. It's just not narratively satisfying to me if the players managed to get all their ducks in a row and then a bad roll punishes them by making their followers *riot*. Plus, anyone at the camp knows what's going on with this cabal. They're at least a *little* prepared to see something this strange.

If it's the Bad ending, though, and Frank Thomas is ascending? The effect is kind of scary and it's not even clear it's beneficial, so you can lop off two of those beneficial riot shifts. Now you only have -10 for a receptive crowd--and if the players created *enough* chaos around their followers in the leadup to the ritual, maybe not even that. And it makes a lot more sense that followers might riot, suddenly regretting what they've committed to and freaking out that Frank Thomas is now a *god*.

of four activists who can bend the revolutionary fervor of their followers to their cause.

These four were brought together by Frank Thomas, an ex-marine based in Crossways, Georgia who launched the plan after learning about Counter-Insurgency (COIN) in Afghanistan and pursuing the original source of the stratagem: Mao. But Frank's research brought him somewhere a lot deeper, and a lot stranger. Using the power of the Firebrand Archetype, he could ascend to the heavens to become the Red Flag of the Vanguard itself--and implant himself in the subconscious mind of humanity, inspiring the world to revolutionary fervor. It was a project he built over months and then years, drawing a close cadre of potential revolutionaries to his side, but a ritual found in Crossways Baptist church by cadre member Jordan Andrews promises to *immanentize the revolutionary eschaton*--ascending Frank immediately to the collective unconscious and creating a magically hidden Shadow Realm in the swamps of Okefenokee, the perfect base from which to launch a full-scale insurrection in the swamps of Georgia.

PROLOGUE

Give the PCs a few minutes to internalize what they read in their secrets. It's good to spend a little time building up the character beats in the "GETTING INTO CHARACTER" section so that when each PC opens their "SECRET", what they find out is genuinely shocking, and they're forced to scramble a little to decide what they want to do. While they're deciding, you can read the below text (or alter it to your taste.)

It's late April in Okefenokee Georgia, a huge, enormous stretch of seven-hundred square miles of swamp. The oppressive heat of a Georgian summer has not yet settled in and you've set up camp after the torrential rains of early spring, making the swamp almost, for a moment, seem pleasant. Trees rise out of the lazily flowing rivers and are densely hung with spanish moss. You've set up on an island known colloquially as "Soldier's Camp", a long-unoccupied site known as a former hideout of confederate deserters and runaway slaves during the Civil War. Frank and Ben James' have set up a circle of tents on the island with mosquito netting in preparation for the summer onslaught, and there are three small motor boats they've acquired that help circumnavigate the swamp. Although you still move freely between Crossways and Soldier's Camp for supplies at this point, Jordan Andrews is teaching everyone how to fish in the swamp and trap groundhogs while Ben teaches the members of the camp to fire a gun and hunt deer and gator.

Frank Thomas' stays in the largest tent at the head of the camp, which he shares with Destiny Jones. This tent also serves as the HQ when he is plotting strategy with Dan and Ben or discussing the ritual with Jordan. The rest of your tents are arrayed close beside his.

It's 6:30pm on Saturday and you've all just finished chicken dinner. Frank Thomas wipes off his hands and addresses the players.

"I'm so blessed to have loyal comrades like y'all here. I realize what we're undertaking--immanentizing the eschaton, launching a guerilla war--is extremely ambitious. When we finish our work here, when I've ascended, we can be the vanguard that inspires the workers to throw off the chains of capitalism. I know that together we can accomplish this, working in that solidarity--for when the worker is united, no force on earth can stop him.

Monday is May Day; International Worker's Day. There is no day more potent for our ritual, and it's absolutely essential that you acquire any remaining items needed by Jordan so we can complete our work on May first. If not, I fear the flame of the revolution will sputter as soon as it's lit." Frank Thomas should then roll *Demagogue*. If he is successful, ask the players--out of character--if they have any objection to Frank's demand. If they do, it is a *rank 5 helplessness check*.

Frank Thomas then returns to his tent and you're sitting around an extinguished campfire on scattered lawn chairs and logs. There are a few other followers milling about. You all look and feel tense, as if something weighs upon your mind beyond the enormity of what you are undertaking. You know that Jordan still needs to acquire a couple of items for the ascension ritual and it has taken longer than you hoped. You aren't sure what they are, though, and you have things of your own on your mind.

WE ARE STRUGGLING TOGETHER

Typically, Jordan will share the items she needs for the ritual with the rest of the cabal, as she'll need them regardless of who she thinks is worthy of ascension. But if Jordan is not forthcoming or wanders off alone to find them, have Frank ask one of the players if they can track down the gun of an American Rebel and Confederate deserter, *Romulus Morgan*, to increase his symbolic potency as a Firebrand for the ritual. If a player has chosen the *protégé* role for Frank, they'll know this anyway, as part of their secret, and they may bring it up independently without Frank mentioning it--give them a chance to share the info before bringing in Frank.

A lot of the game's flow stems from how openly antagonistic the players want to be toward each other. You should bend the game to fit their playstyle as much as possible; if you have players who are competitive, encourage them to roll Firebrand against each other to move their percentiles. If the players are cooperative, encourage role-play that brings out dramatic moments that display their consensus' candidate's camaraderie with the cabal. If players start "teaming up" based on their inter-cabal relationships, play up their friendships with each other and divisions with the other members of the cabal. At all times, drive the players towards the decisions they will have to make before the ritual happens, and play referee if needed to make any conflicts and arguments drive the story forward instead of becoming repetitive, drawn-out bickering.

Up/Speak Up," if she so chooses. The GM decides that becoming the embodiment of the people is close enough to count as that noble passion, and she rolls a 58, which passes. Since her archetype is not over 100%, however, she does not ascend.

ii. Jordan has a Firebrand of 106%, and rolls a 90. She passes, and ascends!

iii. Dan has a Firebrand of 59%, and rolls a 66. This is a matched failure, but it doesn't matter since the roll is pass/fail. That said, it does mean that a flip-flop won't help him. His noble passion is "Teaching the People," but he already used it earlier to get a GMC on his side.

iv. Ben has a Firebrand of 61% and rolls a 62. He uses his obsession identity to flip-flop it into a success, at 26. This passes, but this is still not a "winning" roll if he wants to ascend; his identity is not at 100% for the roll, so he cannot ascend.

v. Frank has a demagogue of 60% after Dan's whammy, and rolls a 30. This passes, but his roll is not high enough to ascend.

3. After these rolls, the GM determines that Jordan is successful in changing the ritual so that *she*, and not Frank, ascends as the Red Flag of the Vanguard.

WHAT THE RITUAL LOOKS LIKE

As the ritual begins, a flock of ghosts wearing red join the players in their hymnal, circling widdershins beside them. They are escaped slaves, confederate deserters and their wives, and underground railroad conductors. Then:

THE ASCENSION

This only occurs if someone's archetype after a shift is over 100%. If a Firebrand reaches ascension, an aura of red surrounds them and a pillar of light falls from the sky. They rise into the air as they slowly dissolve from toe to head. If a player ascends, they exist now in the Statosphere, aware of all the comings and goings of Firebrands on the entire Earth, able to subtly and almost imperceptibly--but materially--influence the path of their organizing, the way a charismatic leader influences a crowd. The players feel a sense of renewed hope in their ability to inspire a new wave of resistance using their secret base at Soldier's Camp.

If Frank Thomas ascends, as the players watch him dissolve into a pillar of light, a feeling of fervor and anger rises within them. The only path forward for American Freedom is war. Unrelenting commitment to guerilla war, until the name of Frank Thomas, the Red Flag of the Vanguard is on the lips of the entire country... and then the world.

THE CREATION OF THE HIDDEN BASE

As long as someone passes, even if no one ascends, the base is successfully created. The players watch as the ghosts of confederate deserters, runaway slaves,

- Jordan is the one with the actual ascension ritual and the only one that knows how to use it--so by cunning and guile, she can ensure anyone she wants is holding the appropriate gun and is the one to release Chipper.
- If the players do manage to complete the ritual on May Day, it will grant them an extra 5% shift. (So 25% total.)
- Dan Cooper's gutter magick ritual is a *Whammy* per page 179 of *Play*. It works exactly the opposite of a *Boon*, taking away -20% from Frank's (or whoever he targets) ascension roll--so, if the target is Frank, effectively Frank would be at 55% in Demagogue during this one ritual.

MATH TIME

Once you've figured out how all the rolls stack, have all of the characters roll their archetype. The ascension is structured for the "winner" to ascend primarily based on the *power of the characters' archetypes after the ritual and gutter magick shifts*, not how well they roll. **This is very important!** If the ritual just prioritizes who rolls the best success, then the weakest avatar could easily be the one to ascend if they happen to get lucky. That would really suck for all of the players who have been working diligently throughout the entire one-shot to pump their skill up! The roll's only function is to serve as a trigger for all the magick they've been setting up over the course of the adventure. **The ascension roll itself is pass or fail, and the number on their die does not matter beyond that.**

Here's how to run it:

1. Have all of the players roll their Firebrand skill and roll Frank Thomas' Demagogue skill while they are doing that, assuming they are all participating in the ritual. Tell them how their skill is altered for the shift. So if Destiny has a 40% shift because of two rituals, *during this roll*, she has a Firebrand skill of 111%.
2. Of the players who successfully pass their roll, the player with the best *Firebrand identity* wins. **Again**, it doesn't matter which players' roll is "best"--as long as they pass, what matters is the strength of their archetype embodiment after their roll shift. Also, if they fail, remember they can flip-flop or reroll if their Noble passion is in play (and it probably is), if they haven't used it already. Additionally, each player is also using their Firebrand identity, which is their obsession, giving them another chance to flip-flop a failure. **Finally, remember--someone's shift needs to combine to over 100%, or none of them ascend.**
 - a. Example: Destiny, Jordan, Ben, and Dan all roll their Firebrand identity, while Frank rolls his Demagogue identity. Destiny successfully cast a *gutter magick* boon on Jordan Andrews, granting her a +20% shift, while Jordan has arranged the ascension ritual so she gets the +20% shift to her avatar ability, and not Frank. Meanwhile, Dan has been casting a *whammy* on Frank to take his avatar ability down -20%. The GM asks them all to roll their Firebrand identity.
 - i. Destiny has a Firebrand of 71%, and rolls a 97. This is a failure. A flip-flop using her obsession, *Firebrand*, will not help her, but she can re-roll using her noble passion, "Inspire others to Stand

During the course of the module, players may try to use the first channel, which allows them to siphon points off of a Firebrand and onto themselves. In fact, I recommend overtly mentioning this channel and invoking this channel *any* time one Firebrand rolls against another Firebrand, even if they're not *specifically* using this channel. If one Firebrand PC rolls against *another* Firebrand PC, Try to describe how that might feel in the metafiction for them as well as giving them the numbers--To whomever succeeds, "something almost imperceptible changes in the way they carry themselves; you can feel yourself, for half a second, almost looking down on them as they look up, not in a debasing or pitiable way, but in the way a one looks up to a role model or a hero--someone equal to them but with qualities they have to, on some level, admire and wish to emulate."

If your players try to use the first channel to "Firebrand off" with *Frank*, you should mention that their percentile does not change--for better or worse. You should tell them that nothing "feels" different about their relationship with Frank--he doesn't respect *them* any more than before. You don't respect *him* any more than you used to. If you have players who are paying attention, this may be their biggest signal that Frank is not actually a Firebrand. See I CAN'T HELP BUT NOTICE (pp24) for more details.

EMOTIONAL LABOR

Before the secrets are revealed, players may enter Firestarter thinking the game is going to be about fighting external threats. But at its core, Firestarter is about the internal threats of running a revolution. Players bent toward cooperation and not full-on conflict will generally reveal their secrets and try to chart a plan forward. But this is often when the real conflict begins, and you should be a little prepared to play referee to keep those conflicts constructive and play-oriented, not endless circular back-and-forth. So here's some tips and tricks!

- If the players get in a circular in-character argument with no clear end-point, gently interrupt the argument. Tell each player they get one "final remark" one after the other from right to left.
- Then, have them all roll Firebrand and eke percentiles from each other. Explain that the winning roll feels the most leader-like, with an aura of command and sincerity. But don't force them to follow that person's lead--simply convey that that is how they momentarily feel.
- Ask each player what they, personally, plan to do.
 - If they say they'd like to take a vote, have them do so in character.
 - Note they cannot bind other players to the result of a vote.
 - If the players decide to go against the will of the winning Firebrand, that's fine! But they will take a Self 3 check, higher if you think they are acting out of line with one of their passions (see Book 1: Play, Coercion, pp56.)
 - If a vote is taken and the player decides to act against the will of the majority, they will take an Isolation 4 check, higher if you think they are acting out of line with one of their passions (see Book 1: Play, Coercion, pp56.)
 - If the players act in line with the winning Firebrand's suggestion, give them a 10% shift to any rolls for minutes equal to the winning roll.
- Give the players one final go around, from left to right, for closing remarks or

comments. Then conclude the conversation and if necessary, end the scene.

Regardless, the players will probably take one of the below actions, or some combination thereof:

- They will aid Jordan in acquiring the final two things she needs to complete the ritual, or go into Crossways to get the things *they* need for *their* ritual. See [THE BARREL OF A GUN](#) (pp16), [METAPHYSICAL SHOPPING](#) (pp17), and [FREE CHIPPER](#) (pp18). Players will often gravitate toward finding Chipper and the guns first, because it gives them time to mentally process their secrets and suss out if the other players are trustworthy.
- They will wander off to get the items they need for their ritual by themselves. This will almost certainly necessitate their going into town independently. (See [METAPHYSICAL SHOPPING](#) pp17.) There's only three boats, so either they'll have to uneasily team up or one person will be left behind, which may set them up for being frank with Frank (See [COMBAT LIBERALISM](#) pp21.)
- Some or all of the PCs may decide that it is not very activist to sneak around behind Frank's back and they will confront him head-on, struggle session style. (See [COMBAT LIBERALISM](#) pp21.) Most players seem to choose to do this last, as a group, once they have built up some mutual trust.

1. WHERE IS COMRADE FRANK

After Frank has left, it's likely that the players will immediately begin trying to figure out how to complete their own objectives and acquire ingredients for the ritual as a cabal. Frank can exist basically *in absentia* for most of the one-shot until the characters decide to confront him or stage the ritual itself.

Don't sweat about making Frank an active force during the game. He doesn't need to "drop in" or direct the action if the players don't invite his presence. Frank is largely a reactive force, appearing only when and where doing so will apply pressure on the players to complete the objective or make his dark secrets seem more pressing and important. Here are a few ways players might engage with Frank. If a player or players are *confronting* Frank, not spying or conversing with him non-confrontationally, you should reference the [COMBAT LIBERALISM](#) (pp21) section, which goes in depth on how he will try to defend himself and manipulate them.

RED-COLORED GLASSES

Most players who choose Frank as a "Favorite" see him as an important force in their life. *Some* players who choose Frank are inviting a romantic subplot--and you should check with the player if they are, and if so, *what their comfort level is*. A player who wants the bitterness of a fraught romance in their game will appreciate those undertones being explicitly added. A player who is *not* inviting that will very much *not* and this could make them really uncomfortable. You should also check if the player wants those feelings to be out in the open between Frank and them or hidden and unrequited.

will ascend on the wings of justice and its wake will be the pole of a tent of safety and succor for those fighting the good fight for the freedom of men.

HOW THE RITUAL WORKS

The ritual works, essentially, by padding any avatar's power by 20% who is on an avatar path that "fights for the people" and fulfills the requirements of the candidate in the ritual. (So: free Chipper and hold the symbolically appropriate gun.) Holding the ritual on May Day pads an extra 5% on the ritual because it is such a symbolically potent day for mass movements. For Frank Thomas, who has 75% in Demagogue, this puts him at the level he needs to join the invisible clergy. (If you haven't read [Book 1, Play](#), and don't know what I'm talking about--don't worry about it too much. The short version is, if you get to 100% in your avatar, you're the god-like embodiment of your archetype in a higher plane of existence known as the Statosphere. You can find out more about this on pp96 of [Book 1: Play](#), "[Assumption](#)." I'm also playing a little fast and loose with UA canon but this is a one-shot, so like, don't lose too much sleep over it.)

"But wait a second," you, the GM, may be thinking to yourself. "This is not enough to make any of the *player characters* ascend." You are correct! The next highest PC is Destiny Jones at 73% and that 25% only puts her to 98. At that percentile, she's not even a Godwalker, let alone ascending! And the ritual only ascends one avatar--so it's best if someone is *higher* than Frank, or, if they're at the same percentile, a better embodiment of the people's will. (Which, as Firebrand and not a Demagogue, I would argue they are. But I'll let you decide how easy to go on your PCs.)

How are the players supposed to win? Each player's ritual power affects their standing personally, but if you *stack* their rituals, they ensure more and more success. You can find the rules to all of these gutter magick rituals on pp180 of [Play](#), though it's important to note that the *Proxy* ritual below is altered for the purposes of this one shot from how it works in the book. (A proxy ritual that worked like this in a normal, long-term UA game would be broken as hell.) Here's how all the character's rituals work for them:

- First, the reverse *Proxy* ritual. For this ritual, Ben James is trying to fool the universe into believing that *he is* Frank Thomas. Once the ritual has fired off and *before* you have the final round of Firebrand rolling, have Ben James and Frank Thomas roll. The highest roll "wins" the *Proxy* contest, and the universe believes that *man* is Frank Thomas for the duration of the ritual. Note that this isn't the Firebrand roll like in these other cases. This is just raw luck, a pure percentile roll. Since it works like a *Proxy* roll, the highest roll is "it."
- Destiny Jones' gutter magick ritual works per a *Boon* on page 179 of [Play](#), granting any Firebrand she uses it on +20% to their roll during the ascension-off.

IS FRANK THOMAS DEAD?

Maybe your players don't pussyfoot around, and when one of them finds out their bad secret about Frank or reads that they could get his spot, they just fucking kill the guy, and he's not a candidate for ascension because he's, uh, dead.

First of all, make sure to warn your players how deadly combat in UA is per my introduction. That said, this isn't a terrible idea, as long as you're smart about it. If Frank is dead, just run the ritual with the same rules, ignoring anything that would have affected only Frank. (remember, it's possible for Ben to cast his proxy ritual on another candidate for ascension!)

6. WIDDERSHINS

After the players have prepared for the ritual, they should meet up with all of the other members of the cabal at Soldier's Camp to perform the ritual. This will probably be in the same clearing where the game starts. Remember, the hidden base for the Maoist guerilla war will pop up *wherever the ritual is performed*, so it's best to do it somewhere hidden.

That said, if the players really wow you by choosing a location with a lot of symbolic resonance that's appropriate for a guerilla war, feel free to add an extra 5-15% to the 20% shift provided by the ritual (see *How the Ritual Works*.) However, Soldier's Camp itself is famous as the site of a confederate deserter and layout gang colony during the Civil War--so if the players choose something else, it should only get a bonus if it has *better* symbolic resonance for their candidate than Soldier's Camp already does.

Then the players should perform the ritual, per Jordan's instructions.

RITEUAL: ASCENSION OF THE VANGUARD

- First, the candidate for ascension must free a trapped/bound innocent from their binds. This need not be literal but should be symbolically potent.
- Sing two hymnals that represent your man of the people in the manner of the Sacred Harp, simultaneously. ("Solidarity Forever" and "John Brown's Body" acapella.)
- Circle widdershins in time to the meter of the hymnal.
- The candidate for ascension must hold the gun of an American Rebel they identify with who fought for the people.
- As the candidate walks to the hymnal, they will be known for ascension by the sidearm they carry and their role in the freeing of the innocent. Their soul

If your player has decided to add the romantic undertones to "Favorite," There's an instant veneer of sadness, since the Favorite does not know Frank has been making sexually-charged comments about a cabal-member. This relationship has additional complexity layered on top of *that* if it turns out *they're* the one Frank is making the comments *about*. If the Favorite speaks to Frank alone, Frank is focused on the ascension and mentally preparing himself by reading up on Mao and Marx, maybe even annoyed that the PC isn't helping find ritual components. As far as the Favorite knows, this may be one of their last chances to spend time with Frank before he's gone to them forever, so a standoffish lover or a romance that can never be consummated will be a source of pain, even as a good comrade will understand the pressing importance of fulfilling the ritual. If Frank reciprocates the Favorite's feelings, The only thing Frank will agree to take time away from focusing on being "mentally ready" for the ritual is one last brief rendezvous. You should fade to black for this.

INTENSE BUT ORDERLY WORK

Some players may decide to spy on Frank or be on the constant lookout for any spies that he may have sent to watch them. Generally, my policy is that Frank isn't doing much spying because he's leaving that to whomever picked him as their *Responsibility*, and if no one chose that role for Frank, then he probably honestly trusts them all. But, if the players are *really fixated* on what Frank is up to, here are some things you could use to keep them engaged.

- **Frank is searching for Jordan's ritual:** Jordan knows the ritual. She presumably has it written down or found it written down *somewhere*, but never shared it except for talking of it verbally. Frank might search through her stuff to try and find it.
- **Romping Through the Swamp:** In frustration, Frank might begin searching the swamp randomly for the gun of an American Rebel. This could open the players to seeing the Ghosts of the Swamp themselves. You should roll to see if Frank is successful; if he botches, feel free to have a ghost possess him and retrieve the gun. He should move and act oddly if this happens for as many minutes as the roll's value. (So, rolling a 59 would make him act oddly for 59 minutes.)
- **Nervous Followers:** Although Frank is not sending any followers after the players or having them deliberately spy on the players, if the players are sneaking around or whispering a lot, or just acting oddly, the followers may be hanging around because they have noticed that something is... off. If the players start canvassing the Maoist followers to see if Frank has been mistreating *them*, too, they should be familiar with his short temper but mention that he always tries to make good in his own way. Frank isn't sloppy enough to coerce, threaten, or harass followers who don't have as much proven loyalty, but he is extremely hardened and might give off a cold "vibe."

2. THE BARREL OF A GUN

Unlike Chipper, there's no convenient plot coupon to hand to the players on where and how to find the gun of an American Rebel who fought for the people. No matter what happens, when the players *return* to Soldier's Camp with their ritual components, they will meet the Harbingers (pp19) and can ultimately find a gun that way. But it's useful to give the players a chance to find the gun on their own, or at least have them construct their own bread crumbs that will lead them to finding the ghosts.

If the players come up with some good ideas for where to find out about the guns of local rebels on their own, I recommend piggy-backing on their ideas and working the backstories of the HARBINGERS (pp20) into wherever they suggest, rather than forcing a roll or steering them somewhere specific. If a player chose the *protégé* relationship, they may specifically mention Romulus Morgan as well and build out ideas based on Morgan's background.

While the players may just decide to push off finding the gun until after they collect Chipper, if they seem fixated on brainstorming around where to find the rebel gun and they just seem to be floundering, feel free to have Dan Cooper roll his *History Professor* identity to generate some ideas of where to find the rebel gun. Whether the roll is a success or a failure, you should give him *something* to move forward with, but the success can determine how good the lead is:

- **Critical Success:** Dan remembers hearing rumors in town of one of the guns that the Ghosts (pp20) lead the players to. Generally this should be David Redpath's gun, since that is the gun that mirrors Dan, but if Dan is clearly supporting someone else's bid for Red Flag of the Vanguard, you should steer him to that gun instead.
- **Matched Success:** Dan met the curator of the historical society, Aaron Martin, once and still has his number. He knows details about specific confederate deserters and underground railroad runners/escapees from this area.
- **Success:** Dan knows where in town the historical society is located and could visit it for ideas.
- **Failure/Matched Failure:** Dan thinks he remembers hearing that some confederate deserters and slaves were buried in a nearby graveyard.
- **Fumble:** Dan is possessed by one of the Harbingers and immediately begins heading through the swamp to retrieve their gun. Dan should lead the players to one of the guns mentioned under GHOSTS OF THE SWAMP. Once he has the gun, Dan briefly blacks out and wakes with no memory of what has happened.

WHAT HAPPENS TO FRANK?

Eventually, Frank will either be confronted and asked to step down, or the ritual will complete (See WIDDERSHINS pp26). If Frank is confronted collectively by the PCs or the ritual completes *without* his ascension, Frank will be left without a base of support.

A Demagogue is unlike a Firebrand in that Firebrand's archetype draws its power from the strength of your *ability to build a movement*. Demagogues draw their power from *commanding and manipulating a movement*. Many players won't even demand that Frank leave the compound, they'll simply demand that he step down as leader. But to someone channeling the Demagogue archetype, being a part of something isn't good enough. If *they're* not the leader, *no one* is.

Frank's exact reaction depends on the players, but it will probably end with him running off. Players making successful coercion rolls can elicit a stress check and a probable *fight* reaction from Frank, but he should generally only *choose* to physically fight them if he thinks he can win (and unless they're alone, he probably can't.) If the followers are there, Frank may try to solicit sympathy from the followers; you can have him and the Firebrands roll, but unless they reach some highly improbable roll state like Frank rolling a critical and everyone else failing, it's going to be hard for even a very powerful Demagogue to sway the opinions of a group of followers over *four Firebrands*. (His chances improve if fewer Firebrands are confronting him!)

If the players threaten bodily harm on Frank, then you're probably rolling combat. If they don't plan on killing him, this generally means grappling on the grid-iron. Frank's having a gun or not should depend on what he is doing at the time; if he's doing something sedentary or non-threatening, like reading, he probably does not have a gun on him. If it's right after the ascension ritual, he almost certainly *does*. But even then, I personally don't have Frank shoot at the players unless he's *extremely* cornered, because there's no world in which a lone man shooting at his cadre in full view of everyone else is a winning move. (That's a world in which Ben James is probably going to shoot back.)

This is why it's most dangerous for players to confront Frank alone. This is the only situation in which a shooting someone could stand to his benefit, if he can make the person "disappear" in the swamp before the body is seen and create a plausible lie for the sound of gunshot.

If there's no plausible way for Frank to turn the situation at Soldier's Camp to his advantage or regain leadership, he should run away. The players are welcome to pursue him if they want to make sure he won't talk, but their magical shadow realm does grant them some level of protection from interlopers.

worth the credibility hit when an apology will probably patch things over.

STRESS CHECKS LIKE FLIES ON SHIT

Depending on how many players are confronting Frank and how much, you could be rolling several stress checks in a scene. Some of these stress checks are pretty high and it's very likely some of the players will fail them. If you're never played *Unknown Armies* before, failing a stress check is actually a pretty big event in a session. Everything stops as the player has to make a decision about how they cope with what is basically a panic attack. Even if they pass the stress check, you should take the time to explain that they are really discomfited or upset by what is being said. It may also make the players think something weird is going on, as in, like, something supernatural that can't be explained by normal coercion. (Especially since all four of the players have supernatural compulsion abilities themselves.)

If the players choose to confront Frank at the top of the game, rather than later on, making so many stress checks may encourage the Players to do the rest of... whatever they're planning while avoiding Frank. This is probably a good idea. If the players confront Frank but don't actually chase him out of Soldier's Camp, tie him up, or kill him, and he thinks he can turn all of the followers against them, he may very well try this. See *Firebrand Followers* (pp36) and *Frank Thomas* (pp33) for stats to calculate if he is successful.

I CAN'T HELP BUT NOTICE

In addition to the weirdness of getting stress checks so extremely thick and fast, any players that try to "Firebrand off" with Frank will not be able to eke any percentiles away from him, as he is the Demagogue archetype and not a Firebrand at all. If they confront him about *that*, Frank doesn't know or understand what they're talking about, which is probably an honest answer, because he's never felt what it's like to siphon off points from a Firebrand avatar in this way. How sinister you run Frank is kind of up to you based on what you think is interesting, but personally, I don't think even Frank knows he's not channeling the spirit of the Firebrand. But whatever *Frank* believes, this might be a signal to the players that he's not like them after all.

Whether the players infer that something is supernaturally *off* about Frank from the number of stress checks he forces or their inability to siphon off points, you should encourage them to come to any conclusions about this they're beginning to sniff out with a good *Secrecy* or *Firebrand* roll. Don't be too specific, but cue them into the fact that "you think maybe something *else* is moving Frank besides the spirit of the Firebrand."

AARON MARTIN AND THE HISTORICAL SOCIETY

Aaron Martin (pp37) runs the local historical society building in Crossways, and if Dan successfully finds his number, he can call him and ask him where he might be able to find the gun of a revolutionary. If a member of the cabal has a sincere, open conversation about their revolutionary activities and/or makes a successful *connect* roll Aaron will offer Dan his own gun from his days as a member of the *Black Liberation Army* under the condition that they swear not to reveal his former involvement with that organization.

Otherwise, Aaron Martin reveals the location of the abandoned Peace Society Building (see: *A SPOOKY HOUSE* pp21) and the existence of an abandoned lean-to he believes was a shelter for escaped slaves and deserters (see *HARBINGERS* pp20.)

If Dan remembers the existence of the Historical society and visits it directly, it's located in the old rail depot in a three room storefront with a small office in the back. The main portion of the museum is devoted to the history of the railroad in Crossways, but rifling through the back office or asking about historic rebels will lead the players to maps--these are maps *Aaron Martin* has drawn with likely paths through the swamp that ferried slaves north and brought supplies to the layout gangs. Following these paths will lead the players to the *SPECTRES HAUNTING THE SWAMP* (pp19).

THE GRAVEYARD

Finally, Dan can try going to the graveyard to find the grave of a rebel and exhume it. The Crossways graveyard is located adjacent to the swamp down a dirt road, and there are graves from all eras here, including old, unmarked stones inset into the ground. When Dan visits the graveyard, he realizes upon arriving at the graveyard that any slaves or confederate deserters would be miserably poor and most likely buried in an unmarked grave. As he is getting discouraged, he and any other Firebrands with him should roll per the instructions in *GHOSTS OF THE SWAMP* (pp19)--the ghost will lead the Firebrand to one of the Harbinger's guns.

3. METAPHYSICAL SHOPPING

The characters will have to enter Crossways to, at a minimum, go to the Treeseum to find Chipper, the mummified hound dog trapped in the center of a chestnut tree. (unless they figure out something else in the swamp.) They may also look for other gutter magic or ritual components here, like the trappings of rebellion to use on whomever Destiny wants to ascend or the trappings that symbolize whomever Dan wants to put the whammy on. (Though Dan may be better off raiding their actual belongings than things they like or represent them... if he can get away with it.)

There is also a large All-Mart in town, the selfsame one Jordan once worked at, which she can try to recruit from if she so desires.

THE CONFEDERACY IS NOT A REBEL CAUSE

If the players are looking for symbolic trappings of a rebellion for the subject of a boon, *don't* use Confederate symbols. If the ghosts weren't a big enough hint, the real rebels here are confederate draft-dodgers, layout gangs and deserters, escaped slaves and their rescuers, and underground railroad conductors and anti-war activists. Not Confederates. If your players start thinking "I can make someone symbolize rebellion by draping them in a Confederate flag" explain that communists would know that the Confederates represented the power of capital in the 19th century American South because a) they were the dominant power in Georgia at the time of the Civil War and b) The Confederacy was run by and for the rich planter class of the South, not scrappy, poor underdogs. (Draping the the boon in an *American* flag also won't work, for similar reasons--the US Flag is a symbol of a dominant power, not rebels, and it was even at the time of the Civil War.)

FREE CHIPPER: THE TREESEUM

The Treeseum is a large, circular building on the outskirts of Crossways. There's an old train locomotive under an overhang, a children's playground, and some nearby hiking trails through a park. The museum is closed Sundays and Mondays and is open 10am-2pm the rest of the week.

Inside the Treeseum has a broad, open floor plan, not unlike a round barn. There is a large fiberglass tree that talks when approached, saying canned phrases like "Welcome to the Wonderful World of Trees!" and "Walk inside my trunk to learn about humanity's relationship with trees!" There is a large window through which a gigantic cypress tree can also be seen outside, the same type of tree that dots the swamps of Okefenokee.

There is a large staircase around the center of the mostly-open floor plan that leads to three small floors of exhibits. As the star attraction, Chipper is on the top floor under a fiberglass case.

There's no guards at the Treeseum--it's not the kind of place that expects a lot of robberies. But there are cameras recording the premises. This isn't a heist crew and any solutions that players come up with are going to be ersatz and sloppy. That's okay--as long as they aren't recognized and get out of there without someone getting a clear shot of their license plates or where they're headed, they should be

convince the PCs that their cabalmate is lying. The more PCs there are the harder this is as a practical matter. Resisting this particular lie is going to be an *isolation* check: 7 for Ben, 4 for Jordan, 3 for Destiny, and 4 for Dan.

- If there are not other PCs present, Frank will downplay both the seriousness of the comments and the seriousness of his intention to follow through with them. If the PC chooses to be the *victim*, this is going to be around a *Isolation* 5 check. The good news is: It's easier to *coerce* Frank into admitting he's wrong, because he's alone. If the player coerces Frank, he should generally admit that he was wrong if they succeed on their roll, which will lower his percentile in *Demagogue*, but he should ask that they not tell anyone else what he did. If they say no, have him use a channel to push the Belief that revealing his harassment is *bad for the cause*. For most characters that's a Self 4-5 check.
- **Frank wants you to blackmail someone who is thinking of leaving the swamp.**
 - If the cops find out about what Frank and the cabal are planning, their movement is absolutely over and dead on arrival. The cops and FBI will not extend the same lack of strong-arm tactics they use on groups like the brown-shirts to us. We either need to have material that keeps deserters from talking, keep them here as prisoners, or kill them outright. This is the most humane of those options, even if they're leaving out of fear and not because they've lost faith in our cause. This channels the idea that letting someone free puts *the cabal*, and *the cause*, in *danger*. This is generally an *isolation* 7 check.
- **Frank wants you to kill a potential traitor in the cabal.**
 - The ritual is a delicate thing, and someone trying to muck around with it or take Frank's place could ensure that it does not work at all or someone that we have not all built consensus around instead of him ascends instead. There's no telling what might happen if someone else ascends and that person is a *traitor to the cause*. This is around an *Isolation* rank 5 check.
- **Frank hit the PC when they could not get a ritual component.**
 - This is the easiest thing to force Frank to take a hit on his Avatar identity for. While many of the other things in this list are *more objectively awful*, this is harder to make an excuse for or explain away as not being in the wrong. Whether Frank admits he was wrong or this or not depends a *lot* on how much consensus there is against him. If Frank thinks he can get away with it, he might try to say that the stakes are so high for the movement and he wanted to impress the importance of the ritual on the person who failed. (This is a typically *Helplessness* rank 2 or 3 check.)
 - But if "it's for the movement" doesn't ding, Frank should admit he let the temper get the better of him from years in the service and a lot of trauma and just take the hit to his *Demagogue*. Saying this was justified probably would not play well with most activists and it's not

There's no way for me to predict everything your players might call Frank out on, but here are potential responses to each scandal and how Frank might try to lie or turn them to his advantage. Some confrontations are easier to force Frank to break taboo on than others. Frank is actually quite principled in terms of what he *actually* believes, he's just constructed elaborate layers of post-hoc reasoning to justify extreme organizing tactics. Or as a fellow organizer told me while writing this, "I wouldn't be surprised if he really thought he was effectively representing a majority of his followers."

Players can also try to *coerce* Frank into agreeing with them, per the rules on pp56 of *Play*. Remember, for every passion in play--both Frank and the PC--the stress check goes up by one dot. They can also try using their second channel to redirect Frank's reasoning to their own, if they can justify to you as the GM that they're actually better representing the movement. If doing this causes Frank to break taboo, he should resist with *Demagogue*, otherwise it's just a straight *Self 5* check on a success.

WHERE ARE YOU GETTING THESE NUMBERS?

In general, the shock gauge difficulties are based on a combination of how much it pushes the PCs buttons and how powerful Frank is. Typically I draw them by looking at an appropriate rank stress check and juicing them a few dots to account for the fact that Frank has the supernatural ability to make people believe something.

You should absolutely tweak them if the players feel like they're making a good show of resisting his rhetoric in-character, increase them if they're not. If you have Frank suss out their passions with his first channel, you can deliberately juice the stress checks by invoking their *Passions*, and then they should be higher.

- **Frank killed an Ali-Mart scab.**
 - Frank will say that his methods were extreme but scabs are the poison that destroys the effectiveness of the union. If we allow scabs to cross picket lines, the work of the union becomes meaningless and it stokes interracial tension as poorly paid workers turn on other, more desperate workers scabbing as scape goats. If we can't rely on them to be principled, we have to make an example of them so picket lines are not crossed by anyone and scabs instead join the picket line as well. If the players push him on this he should insist the scab should have joined the workers, and he tried to convince them but they would not listen. After successfully rolling Demagogue, If the players resist this is around an *Isolation 5* check.
- **Frank sexually harassed or made inappropriate comments about a member of *The Vanguard Spirit*.**
 - If there are other PCs present, Frank will try to deny that this actually happened. Where it goes from here depends a lot on how the PCs react, but if they take the side of the PC, he will use his channels to

fine. The treeseum is outside of Crossways proper and unlikely to be heavily monitored or nearby any cops, and frankly, the players have plenty to worry about without getting into a fight with a bunch of cops. If you think a little heat will get their rears in gear, though, feel free to introduce the police if necessary. (You can use the stats for David Daigle and the Local Cops from *Run Off* if needed.)

CHIPPER

In the center of the third floor is a prominent sign saying "SEE CHIPPER: THE MUMMIFIED DOG." Chipper is a dried-up, desiccated hound dog whose head can be seen inside of a naturally hollowed-out chestnut tree whose top has been cut off to allow visibility inside. There is a plexiglass window affixed to the top of the tree where his head is visible. He tragically went into a tree hollow to investigate it, became stuck, and was only discovered years later when the tree was felled.

IN TOWN

Within the town proper, there are all the normal things you'd expect of a small city--drug store, gun store, gas station, Chicken n' Waffle Hut. There's also a large *All-Mart* (pp37) in town that has all the sundries the player characters might want--the same one from which Jordan was fired. The players buying guns generally shouldn't arouse suspicion unless they are buying *a lot* of them, but they have plenty of guns back at the base for now.

4. SPECTRES HAUNTING THE SWAMP

Once the players have retrieved Chipper and/or investigated where to find the gun of a rebel, returning to Soldier's Camp through the swamp will cause a ghostly figure steering a skiff to appear in front of each of the player's boats. Which ghost appears depends on who is in the boat: the most powerful Firebrand in the boat will generally determine the ghost, but you should feel free to be flexible based on what you think is going to be the most interesting. Only Firebrands can see the ghost, and whichever Firebrands are not the "chosen" player should make a *Firebrand* check to determine if they are also able to see the apparition.

Whichever Firebrand is the most powerful will generally summon a ghost that "reflects" them; If Destiny is being played as "white trash" the wife and supply runner will be a more logical stand-in than if she's being played as a working poor black woman, where the slave liberator would probably make more sense. If you're comfortable with troupe-style play, feel free to let the player that "mirrors" each ghost supply colorful details of what the ghost looks and acts like.

All of the ghosts lead the players to a gun which could be used in the ritual. *None of the guns work*. They are horribly rusted and not salvageable as firearms (and the players have ready access to *working* firearms back at the camp.)

Ghosts are started like revenants; they are Harbingers of a sort, and the entropy of a rebellion (and its symbolic mirroring with their own rebellion) is definitely attracting them, but they aren't as thick on the ground or malicious as the way Harbingers are described on pp106 of Book 2: *Run* are. All of them have the Urge

Support the Rebellion at 45%, but it's unlikely that you will need to roll their stats. Reasoning or communicating with them isn't very effective--they can't speak, and their only real goal is to pass their guns onto the Firebrands. Any conversation should be redirected to that end.

Even if the players have already secured Aaron Martin's gun, you should still include the Harbingers. They serve as a flashpoint for the players, and having more guns forces the players to come to a decision about who they are going to support for ascension. Having only one gun, that of Aaron Martin, may encourage the players to make the decision arbitrarily based on who happened to convince Aaron that the Maoists were trustworthy. Having multiple guns forces the players to make the decision based on who they think is a good leader--or, if more than one player carries a gun on ascension day, gives fate a say in who might become the Red Flag of the Vanguard.

HARBINGERS

- **HARBINGER: THE LIBERATOR OF SLAVES (SYLVIA)**
Sylvia was an escaped slave in life who chose to help other slaves escape servitude. She is a stout, muscular woman with a red bandana tied around her head and a maroon dress. She appears to the player(s) in a skiff and points the way down a creek toward an island where a tall, thick tree stands and a small, rotting lean-to is constructed. The player ventures inside they will find a rusted revolver wrapped in a deteriorating red cloth.
- **HARBINGER: THE WIFE, ROBBER AND SUPPLY RUNNER (ANNE WELSH)** -
Anne was the white wife of a deserter who robbed storehouses and ferried supplies to deserters and escaped slaves. She wears a red calico dress and a red sun bonnet. She appears to the player(s) on a skiff and leads them to the shore near where the road to Crossways lies--there is one of their trucks within view. There she points to a skeleton holding a rifle in their hands.
- **HARBINGER: THE ESCAPED SLAVE (NELSON)**
Nelson is a young black man with red suspenders and a pink shirt. Nelson appears on a skiff in front of the players. He was an escaped slave who helped defend and hide Soldier's Camp alongside confederate deserters and planned raids on plantations. If the players follow his skiff, he leads them to a rusted revolver hidden in a hole in a thick cypress tree.
- **HARBINGER: THE CONFEDERATE DESERTER (ROMULUS MORGAN)**
Romulus is a confederate deserter and wears red canvas pants and a collared shirt with a red hat. He points the way to a rotted out cabin in a nearby island, where the players will find a rusted rifle.
- **HARBINGER: UNDERGROUND RAILROAD CONDUCTOR AND MEMBER OF THE PEACE SOCIETY (DAVID REDPATH)**
David Redpath is wearing a bright red jacket and has a thick beard. If the

players follow his skiff, he leads them to a small abandoned victorian with boarded up windows on the outskirts of the swamp. He points to a rusted revolver hiding underneath the front steps. (If the players somehow miss that he's pointing at the steps and not the house itself, feel free to have them find the gun inside the house, hanging on a mantle.)

A SPOOKY HOUSE

I hope you aren't disappointed to learn that there's actually really nothing of interest inside the house. If the players look in there, it's pretty much empty and abandoned and covered in dust (and probably not structurally sound.) If you think the players are floundering around a lot feel free to put some plot coupons in here. It could also be a great set piece for an argument to break out between the characters over what to do. If tensions are simmering between them, feel free to have some revenants dressed in middle-class clothing of the 19th century fighting. These would be members of The Peace Society (anti-confederate secret societies opposing the war) debating their next move.

5. COMBAT LIBERALISM

"To let things slide for the sake of peace and friendship when a person has clearly gone wrong, and refrain from principled argument because he is an old acquaintance, a fellow townsman, a schoolmate, a close friend, a loved one, an old colleague or old subordinate. ...The result is that both the organization and the individual are harmed. This is one type of liberalism." -Mao Tse Tung, "Combat Liberalism"

Eventually, the players will probably confront Frank. If they're smart, they will do so in a group, where they are more likely to succeed and he is less of a threat to them. In Maoist practice, this is essentially what is called a struggle session.

STRUGGLE SESSION

Frank is a Demagogue (See "**FRANK THOMAS**" in the appendix pp33) and his taboo is that he can *never admit he's wrong*. Frank should attempt to avoid admitting wrongdoing by any means he is effective at. He can also use his channels to suss out and tailor his words to the character's beliefs, so feel free to ask your players what they *want to hear* Frank say, or how they *actually feel* about what he did, or what he might have to say to get them to agree with him. Once you have a sense of that, have him channel his Demagogue powers and try to force them to believe what he's saying. When/if the player resists or refuses to agree, they must take the appropriate *Self, Isolation or Helplessness* check. Note that having more people agreeing with the player characters than Frank means each player can see Frank causing stress checks in other player characters, so the most effective way to confront Frank is as a group.